

Daoxin Li

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Personal

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Education

2024 **Ph.D. in Linguistics**, University of Pennsylvania
Dissertation: *Distributional learning of syntactic generalizations*
Committee: Charles Yang (advisor), Kathryn Schuler (co-advisor), Julie Anne Legate,
John Trueswell, Marlyse Baptista
Certificates in Language & Communication Science; College & University Teaching

2019 **B.A. in English Language**, Tsinghua University

Professional Experience

2025- **Assistant Professor**, Department of Linguistics, University of North Carolina at
Chapel Hill

2024-2025 **Postdoctoral Fellow**, Infant and Child Development Center, Northwestern Univer-
sity (PI: Sandra Waxman)

Awards & Honors

External

2024 Paula Menyuk Travel Award, the 49th Boston University Conference on Language
Development

2024 Student Abstract Award (2nd Place), Linguistic Society of America

2023 Prize for the Best Original Research Article of the Year by an Untenured Scientist,
Language Acquisition

2021 Paula Menyuk Award (awarded to student first authors of top-rated abstracts), the
46th Boston University Conference on Language Development

Northwestern

2024 Conference Travel Grant, Office of Postdoctoral Affairs

Penn

2019-2024 Benjamin Franklin Fellowship (full support for five-year Ph.D. studies)
2019, 2023, Research Travel Grant, Graduate and Professional Student Assembly (GAPSA)
2024
2023 Departmental Conference Travel Reimbursement Fund, Department of Linguistics
2019, 2022 Dean's Travel Subvention, School of Arts and Sciences
(2×), 2023
2021 Travel Grant, Graduate Student Government of the School of Arts and Sciences
(SASGov)
2021 Professional Society Membership Grant, Graduate Student Government of the
School of Arts and Sciences (SASGov)

Tsinghua

2019 Outstanding Graduate Award
2016-2018 Merit-based Undergraduate Scholarship for all school years
2017 Academic Travel Award

Publications

 Google Scholar

→ Trainee co-author

Book Chapters

Becker, M., & Li, D. (Submitted). A modern (linguistic) perspective on Quine's *Linguistics and Philosophy*.

Li, D. & Waxman, S. R. (In press). Infant word learning. In H. Nesi & P. Milin (Eds.), *International encyclopedia of language and linguistics* (3rd ed.). Elsevier. <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-323-95504-1.00857-7> (Advance online publication).

Refereed Articles

Li, D. (2024). Controlling overt subjects in Mandarin. *Journal of East Asian Linguistics*, 33, 333–366. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10831-024-09280-2>

Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2024). Children can use distributional cues to acquire recursive structures. In L. K. Samuelson, S. L. Frank, M. Toneva, A. Mackey, & E. Hazeltine (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society* (pp. 1925–1932). <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3d52v78v>

- Li, D., Yue, C. S., & Trueswell, J. (2024). Is it a bat or a thing? Referential contrast in the learning of homophones and superordinate terms. In L. K. Samuelson, S. L. Frank, M. Toneva, A. Mackey, & E. Hazeltine (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society* (pp. 2301–2307). <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/3h2521vb>
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. D. (2023). Acquiring recursive structures through distributional learning. *Language Acquisition*, 30(3-4), 323–336. <https://doi.org/10.1080/10489223.2023.2185522>
Awarded *Language Acquisition* 2023 Best Paper by an Untenured Scientist.
- Lyu, Q., Zheng, H., Li, D., Zhang, L., Apidianaki, M., & Callison-Burch, C. (2022). Is "my favorite new movie" my favorite movie? Probing the understanding of recursive noun phrases. In M. Carpuat, M.-C. de Marneffe, & I. V. Meza Ruiz (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 2022 Conference of the North American Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics* (pp. 5286–5302). Association for Computational Linguistics. <https://aclanthology.org/2022.naacl-main.388>
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2021). Distributional learning of recursive structures. In *Proceedings of the 43rd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society* (pp. 1437–1443). <https://escholarship.org/uc/item/45221021>
- Yin, L., Joshi, R. M., Li, D., & Kim, S.-K. (2020). Decisions about consonant doubling among non-native speakers of English: Graphotactic and phonological influences. *Reading and Writing*, 33, 1839–1858. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11145-020-10017-5>

Conference Proceedings with Refereed Abstracts

- Li, D. & Schuler, K. D. (2025). Children can use distributional cues to acquire recursive structures. In A. Yedetore, R. D. Bonney, & Y. Zhang (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 49th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 435–448). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclld/49/BUCLD49-33.pdf>
- Li, D. (2024). Modelling the distributional learning of verb argument structure. In H. A. A. Al-Thagafi & J. Ray (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 48th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 313–326). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclld/48/BUCLD48-24.pdf>
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2023). Distributional learning of recursive structures: The role of the structural representation. In P. Gappmayr & J. Kellog (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 47th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 487–498). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclld/47/BUCLD47-40.pdf>
- Li, D., Zhong[#], S., & Schuler, K. (2023). Adapting infant looking time paradigms for the web. In P. Gappmayr & J. Kellog (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 47th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 499–504). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclld/47/BUCLD47-41.pdf>
- Li, D. (2022). Passives, impersonals, and Voice in Sakha. In S. K. Lee, S. Asinari, & S. Lazakovits (Eds.), *Proceedings of the Workshop on Turkic and Languages in Contact with Turkic* (pp. 88–103, Vol. 7). Linguistic Society of America. <https://doi.org/10.3765/ptu.v7i1.5308>

- Li, D.** (2022). Syntactic bootstrapping mental verbs and perception verbs with limited morphosyntactic cues. In Y. Gong & F. Kpogo (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 46th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 428–441). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclid/46/BUCLD46-33.pdf>
- Li, D.**, Grohe, L., Schulz, P., & Yang, C. (2021). The distributional learning of recursive structures. In D. Dionne & L.-A. V. Covas (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 45th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 471–485). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclid/45/BUCLD45-36.pdf>
- Li, D.** (2021). Controlling overt subjects in Mandarin. In P. Farrell (Ed.), *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America* (pp. 303–316, Vol. 6). Linguistic Society of America. <https://doi.org/10.3765/plsa.v6i1.4973>
- Li, D.**, Yang, X., Roeper, T., Wilson, M., Yin, R., Kim, J., Merritt, E., Lopez, D., & Tero, A. (2020). Acquisition of recursion in child Mandarin. In M. M. Brown & A. Kohut (Eds.), *Proceedings of the 44th Boston University Conference on Language Development* (pp. 294–307). Somerville, MA: Cascadilla Press. <https://www.lingref.com/buclid/44/BUCLD44-24.pdf>

Manuscripts in Submission

- Li, D.** & Schuler, K. D. (Revised & resubmitted). Distributional learning of recursive structures: Linear cues and structural representation.
- Li, D.** & Schuler, K. D. (In revision). Children’s distributional learning of recursive structures: Capacities and constraints.

Manuscripts in Preparation

- Li, D.** & Yang, C. (In prep). Productivity and the distributional learning of recursive structure.
- Li, D.** & Trueswell, J. (In prep). One meaning or two? The role of implicit referential contrast in the learning of homophones and superordinate terms.
- Li, D.** (In prep). Verb argument structure rules are learnable from distributional cues.
- Li, D.**, Lobo, A., Nam, C., & Waxman, S. R. (In prep). Infants’ representations of individuals, newly established in a naming episode, guide their reasoning in dynamic change-detection events.

Presentations

→ Trainee co-author

Invited Talks

- Li, D.** (2025). *Learning recursive structures in artificial grammars: Humans vs. language models*. Cognitive Talk Series, Department of Psychology and Neuroscience, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill, Chapel Hill NC, Oct 2, 2025.

- Li, D. (2024). *Distributional learning of syntactic generalizations: The case of verb argument structure*. School of Modern Languages, Georgia Institute of Technology, Atlanta GA, Nov 4, 2024 (Virtual).
- Li, D. (2024). *Adults and children can use distributional cues to acquire recursive structures*. The Learning and Development Lab, Georgetown University, Washington DC, Mar 26, 2024.
- Li, D. (2024). *Modelling the distributional learning of verb argument structure*. The Integrated Language Sciences and Technology (ILST) Seminar, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia PA, Feb 9, 2024.
- Li, D. (2023). *Distributional learning of recursive structures*. The Language Acquisition Lab, University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst MA, Sep 21, 2023 (Virtual).
- Li, D. (2022). *Adapting infant looking time paradigms for the web*. The Integrated Language Sciences and Technology (ILST) Seminar, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia PA, Oct 28, 2022.
- Li, D. (2021). *Distributional learning of recursive structures*. The Integrated Language Sciences and Technology (ILST) Seminar, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia PA, Oct 1, 2021.
- Schulz, P., Li, D., Grohe, L., & Yang, C. (2020). *The distributional learning of recursive structures: The case of possessives in German*. The Language Acquisition Research Center (LARC) Roundtable, University of Massachusetts Amherst, Amherst MA, Oct 30, 2020. (Virtual).

Refereed Conference Presentations

- Li, D., Lobo, A., & Waxman, S. R. (2025). *Infants' individual-level representations, established via naming, support reasoning in dynamic events* [Poster]. The 50th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 50), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 6 – 9, 2025.
- Lobo, A., Li, D., Nam, C., LaTourrette, A., & Waxman, S. R. (2025). *Infants' mental representations of objects persist in an occlusion task* [Poster]. The 2025 Biennial Meeting of the Society for Research in Child Development (SRCD 2025), Minneapolis MN, May 1 - 3, 2025.
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2024). *Children can use distributional cues to acquire recursive structures* [Poster]. The 49th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 49), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 7 - 10, 2024.
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2024). *Children can use distributional cues to acquire recursive structures* [Poster]. The 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci 2024), Rotterdam, Netherlands, Jul 24 - 27, 2024.
- Li, D., Yue, C. S., & Trueswell, J. (2024). *Is it a bat or a thing? Referential contrast in the learning of homophones and superordinate terms* [Poster]. The 46th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci 2024), Rotterdam, Netherlands, Jul 24 - 27, 2024.
- Li, D. (2024). *Modelling the distributional learning of verb argument structure* [Talk]. The 98th annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2024), New York NY, Jan 4 - 7, 2024.
awarded 2nd Prize for LSA Student Abstract Award.

- Li, D.** & Trueswell, J. (2024). *One meaning or two? The role of referential contrast in the learning of homophones and superordinate terms* [Poster]. The 98th annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2024), New York NY, Jan 4 - 7, 2024.
- Li, D.** (2023). *Modelling the distributional learning of verb argument structure* [Poster]. The 48th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 48), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 2 – 5, 2023.
- Li, D.** & Schuler, K. (2023). *Distributional learning of recursive structures: The role of the structural representation* [Poster]. The 45th Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci 2023), Sydney, Australia, Jul 26 – 29, 2023.
- Li, D.** & Schuler, K. (2023). *Distributional learning of recursive structures: The role of the structural representation* [Poster]. The 36th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP 2023), University of Pittsburgh, Pittsburgh PA, Mar 9 – 11, 2023.
- Li, D.** & Trueswell, J. (2023). *Cross-situational learning homophones and general categories: The role of the referential domain* [Poster]. The 97th annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2023), Denver CO, Jan 5 – 8, 2023.
- Zhong[#], S., **Li, D.**, & Schuler, K. (2022). *Adapting infant looking time paradigms for the web* [Talk]. The 47th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 47), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 3 – 6, 2022.
- Li, D.** & Schuler, K. (2022). *Distributional learning of recursive structures: The role of the structural representation* [Poster]. The 47th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 47), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 3 – 6, 2022.
- Lyu, Q., Zheng, H., **Li, D.**, Zhang, L., Apidianaki, M., & Callison-Burch, C. (2022). *Is "my favorite new movie" my favorite movie? Probing the understanding of recursive noun phrases* [Talk]. The 2022 Annual Conference of the North American Chapter of the Association for Computational Linguistics (NAACL 2022), Seattle WA, Jul 10 - 15, 2022.
- Li, D.**, Zhong[#], S., & Schuler, K. (2022). *Adapting infant looking time paradigms for the web* [Talk]. The XXII Biennial International Congress of Infant Studies (ICIS 2022), Ottawa, Canada, Jul 7 – 10, 2022.
- Lyu, Q., Zheng, H., **Li, D.**, Zhang, L., Apidianaki, M., & Callison-Burch, C. (2022). *Is "my favorite new movie" my favorite movie? Probing the understanding of recursive noun phrases* [Poster]. The 9th annual Mid-Atlantic Student Colloquium on Speech, Language and Learning (MASC-SLL 2022), Temple University, Philadelphia PA, Apr 30, 2022.
- Li, D.** (2022). *Passives, impersonals, and Voice in Sakha* [Talk]. The 58th annual meeting of the Chicago Linguistic Society (CLS 58), University of Chicago, Chicago IL, Apr 22 – 24, 2022 (Virtual).
- Li, D.**, Zhong[#], S., & Schuler, K. (2022). *Adapting infant looking time paradigms for the web* [Poster]. The 35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP 2022), University of California Santa Cruz, Santa Cruz CA, Mar 24 – 26, 2022 (Virtual).

- Li, D. (2022). *Passives, impersonals, and Voice in Sakha* [Talk]. The 7th Workshop on Turkic and Languages in Contact with Turkic (Tu+7), University of Connecticut, Storrs CT, Feb 18 – 19, 2022 (Virtual).
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2022). *Acquiring recursive structures through distributional learning* [Talk]. The 96th annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2022), Washington DC, Jan 6 – 9, 2022.
- Li, D. (2022). *Syntactic bootstrapping mental verbs and perception verbs with limited morphosyntactic cues* [Poster]. The 96th annual meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2022), Washington DC, Jan 6 – 9, 2022.
- Li, D. (2021). *Syntactic bootstrapping mental verbs and perception verbs with limited morphosyntactic cues* [Talk]. The 46th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 46), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 4 – 7, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2021). *Distributional learning of recursive structures* [Poster]. The 43rd Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci 2021), University of Vienna, Austria, Jul 26 – 29, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D. (2021). *Controlling overt subjects in Mandarin* [Talk]. The 33rd North American Conference on Chinese Linguistics (NACCL 33), University of Chicago, Chicago IL, Jun 24 – 25, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2021). *Acquiring recursive structures through distributional learning* [Talk]. "Recursion across Languages: The Intricacies of Babel" Workshop, Bucharest, Romania, Jun 1 – 2, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D. & Schuler, K. (2021). *Acquiring recursive structures through distributional learning* [Talk]. The 34th Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing (CUNY 34), University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia PA, Mar 4 – 6, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D., Grohe, L., Schulz, P., & Yang, C. (2021). *The distributional learning of recursive structures* [Short talk]. The 34th Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing (CUNY 34), University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia PA, Mar 4 – 6, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D. (2021). *Controlling overt subjects in Mandarin* [Talk]. The 95th Annual Meeting of the Linguistic Society of America (LSA 2021), San Francisco CA, Jan 7 – 10, 2021 (Virtual).
- Li, D., Grohe, L., Schulz, P., & Yang, C. (2020). *The distributional learning of recursive structures* [Talk]. The 45th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 45), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 5 – 8, 2020 (Virtual).
- Li, D., Yang, X., Roeper, T., Wilson, M., Yin, R., Kim, J., Merritt, E., Lopez, D., & Tero, A. (2019). *Acquisition of recursion in child Mandarin* [Poster]. The 44th annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD 44), Boston University, Boston MA, Nov 7 – 10, 2019. (Accepted as an alternate for talk).
- Li, D., Yang, X., Roeper, T., Wilson, M., Yin, R., Kim, J., & Merritt, E. (2019). *Acquisition of recursion in child Mandarin* [Poster]. The 14th biennial conference on Generative Approaches to Language Acquisition (GALA 14), University of Milano-Bicocca, Italy, Sep 12 – 14, 2019.

Yin, L., Joshi, R. M., Li, D., & Kim, S.-K. (2019). *Graphotactic as well as phonological influences on decisions about consonant doubling among non-native speakers of English* [Talk]. The third annual conference of the Association for Reading and Writing in Asia (ARWA 2019), Birla Institute of Technology and Science Pilani, India, Feb 28 – Mar 1, 2019.

Teaching

F → fall, S → spring

U → undergraduate-level course, G → graduate-level course

As Instructor at UNC-Chapel Hill

2026 S	LING 89: First-Year Seminar - Language and Thought (U; 24 students)
2026 S	LING 490: Advanced Topics in Linguistics - Models of Language Acquisition (U & G; 4 students)
2025 F	LING 401: Language and Computers (U & G; 19 students)

As Teaching Assistant at Penn

2023 F	LING 2700: Language Acquisition (U; 24 students)
2023 S	LING 0001: Introduction to Linguistics (U; 42 students)
2021 F	LING 300: Tutorial in Linguistics (U; 15 students)
2021 S	LING 001: Introduction to Linguistics (U; 37 students)
2020 F	LING 270: Language Acquisition (U; 41 students)

Advising

N.B. All at UNC-Chapel Hill unless otherwise noted.

M.A. Students (Advisor)

2026	Elisei Stakovskii (co-advised with Katya Pertsova)
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M.A. Students (Thesis Committee Member)

2026	Lanna McRae
2026	Zhongyu Hu
2026	Rebecca Galloway
2026	Yiran Li

Undergraduate Research Assistants

2026	Chara Gui (Duke University)
2026	Eric Guo
2026	Norah Sun
2026	Anushri Ghoshal
2025	Lauren Delapenha (Northwestern; Weinberg College Summer Research Grant recipient)
2025	Sanjana Basava (Northwestern)
2024	Izabela Baran (Penn)
2023, 2024	Milana Korobko (Penn)
2023-2024	Zaid Tabaza (Penn; Lila R. Gleitman Undergraduate Summer Research Fellow)
2020-2021	Iris Zhong (Smith College)

High School Students

2026	Purujit Kolar
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Grants

2026	First-Year Seminar Enhancement Fund Project: Course enhancement for LING 89 - Language and Thought (\$300) First-Year Seminar & Launch Program, UNC-Chapel Hill
2024	Small Research Grant Project: Children's distributional learning of recursive structures (\$1,800) Integrated Language Sciences and Technology (ILST) Initiative, Penn
2019, 2022, 2023	Doctoral Research Fund Project: Cross-situational learning homophones and superordinate terms (\$1,500) Language and Communication Sciences (LCS) Program, Penn
2018	Tsinghua Initiative Scientific Research Fund Project: Acquisition of serial verb constructions in Mandarin (10,000 RMB) Tsinghua University

Professional Service

To Field

2025-	Site Coordinator, North American Computational Linguistics Open Competition (NACLO)
2024-	Mentor, Pop-up Mentoring Program, Boston University Conference on Language Development
2024-2025	Member, Committee on Ethnic Diversity in Linguistics, Linguistic Society of America
2019-2024	Editorial Board, Penn Working Papers in Linguistics (PWPL)

Conference Organization

2024	Volunteer, the 3rd Experiments in Linguistic Meaning (ELM) Conference
2023	Volunteer, Locality in Theory, Processing and Acquisition Workshop
2022	Volunteer, the 35th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing
2021	Volunteer, the 34th CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing
2020-2021	Committee Chair, the 45th Penn Linguistics Conference
2019-2020	Organizing Committee, the 44th Penn Linguistics Conference
2019	Volunteer, the 2nd International Conference on Theoretical East Asian Psycholinguistics

To University & Department

2025-	Member, Salary Committee, Department of Linguistics, UNC-Chapel Hill
2021-2024	Mentor, Diversity & Equity Initiative (DivE In) in the Mind Sciences, Penn
2021-2023	Treasurer, Penn Graduate Linguistics Society
2022	Coordinator, Professional Development Workshop Series, Department of Linguistics, Penn
2018-2019	Co-founder & Vice President, Students' Linguistic Society of Tsinghua University

Reviewing

Journals	<i>Collabra: Psychology</i> <i>Journal of Child Language</i> <i>Journal of Chinese Linguistics</i> <i>Journal of East Asian Linguistics</i> <i>Language Acquisition</i> <i>Languages</i> <i>Linguistic Inquiry</i> <i>Perspectives on Psychological Science</i>
Conferences	Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society (CogSci) Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing (HSP) Annual Meeting of the Chicago Linguistic Society (CLS) Biennial Conference on Generative Approaches to Language Acquisition (GALA) Penn Linguistics Conference (PLC)

Memberships

Cognitive Science Society (CogSci)
International Congress of Infant Studies (ICIS)
Linguistic Society of America (LSA)

Professional Development

Member, National Center for Faculty Development and Diversity (NCFDD)
New Faculty Program, Institute for the Arts and Humanities, UNC-Chapel Hill